

– these tools let you limit the quantity of posts, to say one post every half an hour, etc.

Connecting 101

Up to this point, you know how to leverage the various platforms to highlight your interests and showcase yourself well. Now comes the clincher – that final step of connecting with people. Networking as it is taught in business schools falls into the category of "connecting with people for the express purpose of getting something out of them". Although this seems very selfish a motive, one must understand that there is mutual benefit to be derived from connecting with others. Here are some of the things to be kept in mind while reaching out to people.

Cut the desperation: One of the first things you need to know when trying to connect with someone is that you may get the cold shoulder. The proverbial brush off may be just around the corner so be prepared for rejection. Avoid going "please please PLEASE reply to me". If the concerned person sees some mutual benefit in what you're saying and intends to get back to you, he/she will. Coaxing a response won't do you any good. In fact on networks like LinkedIn it's advisable to squeeze in something like this in your first contact – "If this does not interest you please click ignore and request you to not click on don't know this person". This is because LinkedIn is known to freeze add-requests if a certain number of people click on that dreaded button. Another thing is that nonchalance may actually work in your favour, ironically.

Choose the right network: When contacting someone do some research beforehand to figure out whether they are open to being contacted. If the person you are intending to interact with has a web site/blog check to see if they have contact info. Find out where they are most active – Twitter, Orkut, Facebook, or even YouTube. This will ensure that the person is on familiar ground and is receptive when you try to establish contact. An add-request without preamble saying "can we be frands" (*sic*) is not the way to go.

Brevity is the soul of wit: As it turns out it is also the soul of first contact. This problem is not so much present in Twitter as it's geared towards putting your point across in 140 characters or less. Though this may be too little for some people, there's an important lesson to be learnt here. Respect the other person's time and grab his/her

Just good business sense

Shaheen Peerbhai a.k.a @PurpleFoodie tells us about her experience with Social Networking and how she leveraged the tools available.



"When I joined Twitter, I did so to keep in touch with other food bloggers all over. It was more convenient/quicker than writing out long emails. I also looked at Twitter as an alternative to my food blog – (purplefoodie.com) – about things that could be summed up in 140 characters. I made sure I didn't talk about mundane things – updating people about the traffic situation. Twitter and Facebook are the two main tools for reaching my audience via the social network. Updating each place can be cumbersome, so I use Hootsuite and Tweetdeck for that. Also, what's interesting is that the quality of traffic one can get via social networks is much higher than the quality one could get via other sources. The average time spent on my site by someone coming in from a social network is twice the time than someone coming in via a referral link. And how has being on social networks helped me? Driven traffic to my web site, helped reach newer audiences, meet like-minded people, as well as given me more work."

attention quickly. If your subject is too big to be explained in short (and this is something common while contacting people on LinkedIn), break it up into bits. Send in the most important piece first and let the person get back to you. Remember those "Learn More..." buttons? Something in that vein.

Focus on the bigger picture: Though it's a good idea to get straight to the point about what you want, it's also good to focus on the interaction or the relationship you are trying to build. Your communication objective shouldn't merely be about the task at hand. Keep doors open, don't burn bridges, and all that jazz.

Quality not quantity: Once you've made your connection you need to make sure not to bombard them with communication. To keep a connection alive, send out an insightful communication every now and then, but infrequently. For instance take Twitter. If people who have recently followed you find that you have hijacked their timeline, they'll unfollow you without a second thought.

Remember, it's a jungle out there, and you need the right tools to survive and flourish. Happy networking! 📱

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